Common human diseases

Bacterial diseases
- Dysentery
- Plague
- Diphtheria
- Cholera
- Typhoid
- Pneumonia

Viral diseases
- Common cold
- Mumps
- Measles
- Viral hepatitis
- Dengue fever
- Chikungunya
- Chicken pox
- Poliomyelitis

Fungal diseases
- Candidiasis
- Athlete's foot

Protozoan diseases
- Malaria
- Amoebiasis
- African sleeping sickness
- Kala-azar

Helminthic diseases
- Ascariasis
- Filariasis

suffers from such diseases at some time or the other. Most of the bacterial diseases are curable but all viral diseases are not. Some infectious disease like AIDS may be fatal.

Non-infectious diseases are not transmitted from an infected person to a healthy person. In origin they may be genetic (cystic fibrosis), nutritional (vitamin deficiency diseases) and degenerative (arthritis, heart attack, stroke). Among non - infectious diseases, cancer is one of the major causes of death.

7.1.1 Bacterial and viral diseases

Bacterial diseases

Though the number of bacterial species is very high, only a few bacteria are associated with human diseases and are called **pathogenic bacteria**. Such pathogens may emit toxins and affects the body. Common pathogenic bacteria and the bacterial diseases are given in **table 7.1**.

Bacteria spread through air, water or by inhaling the droplets/aerosols or even by sharing utensils, dresses with an infected person. Typhoid fever can be confirmed by **Widal test**.

Viral diseases

Viruses are the smallest intracellular obligate parasites, which multiply within living cells. Outside the living cells they cannot carry out the characteristics of a living organism. Viruses invade living cells, forcing the cells to create new viruses. The new viruses break out of the cell, killing it and invade other cells in the body, causing

Bacterial resistance

If an antibiotic is used too often to fight a specific bacterial infection, the bacteria may become resistant to the specific antibiotic. Hence the specific antibiotic can no longer be used to treat the bacterial infection. Some bacteria have developed resistance to many antibiotics. Therefore, infections caused by these bacteria are difficult to be cured.

Risk of bacterial resistance can be reduced by observing the following steps
- Avoid using antibiotics to treat minor infections that can be taken care by our immune system.
- Do not use an antibiotic to treat viral infections such as common cold or flu.
- Always follow the prescription. Skipping doses or failing to complete the prescription may allow antibiotic resistance to develop.

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